

Community of Practice T&L

Meeting 2

06 May 2026

The meeting focused on identifying what we want to stand out for as a Faculty; highlighting our strengths while also reflecting critically on areas for improvement. The discussion was structured around three key questions:

1. What are we doing really well?
2. What areas need improvement?
3. What are we ready to let go of?

The summary below reflects the collective discussion on the three questions above.

What are we doing really well?

Student-Centred Approach

- We look after our students:
 - Strong focus on equity and accessibility
 - Pedagogy grounded in equity and inclusion
 - Strong emphasis on student experience, including social and environmental justice
- Students have agency to tell their own stories, rather than being directed to do so.
- We support students through:
 - Peer-to-peer support
 - Academic support
 - Access to facilities and resources
- Our location allows us to attract a diverse cohort from across Greater Sydney
- Students are choosing to study with us even when alternative (e.g. family-based) career pathways are available
- Opportunities for students to engage with community
- Teaching is perceived as:
 - Relevant and industry-aligned
 - Addressing contemporary and urgent questions
 - Closer to “real-world” contexts
 - **CATCHPHRASE: “What we teach is what the world needs”**
- We provide both:
 - A physical, in-person experience
 - A meaningful on-campus environment
- Despite being a relatively young university, we host strong legacy programs

Industry and Alumni Engagement

- Strong integration between students, alumni, and industry
- Alumni relationships are a major strength:
 - Alumni actively reach out to stay connected
 - They return to:
 - Mentor students

- Share career journeys and multiple pathways
 - Participate in networking events
- Alumni provide:
 - Internship opportunities
 - Sponsorship in some cases
- Clear emotional connection:
 - Alumni “miss the university” and want to give back
- Strong industry networking events with visible alumni presence
- Emphasis on face-to-face interaction between alumni and student.

International Presence

- Our students are recognised internationally:
 - They are recipients of national and international Awards
 - They have exposure and visibility from outside Australia
- Students value opportunities for recognition and exposure
- International exposure through travelling subjects and student exchange opportunities.

Indigenous Student Presence

- The faculty has the highest number of Indigenous students in the university

What Areas Need Improvement?

Student Support and Experience

- Support systems exist but are not clearly communicated to students
- Need clearer articulation of:
 - What support is available to students at faculty level
 - How students access this support
- The growth in cohort size over the past decade has resulted in an impersonable student experience (less attention from a tutor) – which if were to be solved will have a significant impact on academic workload and capacity
- As we move forward, we need to:
 - Define appropriate cohort sizes per discipline
 - Align workload allocation accordingly
 - Maintain a personalised / boutique experience
 - If this is a strength, we should market it explicitly

Alumni Engagement

- Challenge in maintaining long-term contact with alumni. Our alumni move between companies and countries frequently, and do not use their alumni emails.
- Strategies to continue engaging with alumni and keeping contact should leverage social channels that alumni are active in, such as Instagram and LinkedIn.
- Maintaining strong connections with our alumni is a vital component to our teaching.

Equity and participation (Students from low socio-economic backgrounds - SES)

- Our faculty has lower participation from low SES students compared to the broader university. We need to:
 - Engage earlier with schools and communities.. don't only focus on year 11/12 students.. engage with students at a far earlier stage.
 - Build aspiration. Some students do not see the value of a university education, we should first speak to students about this value, and then showcase our identity to attract them to join us.
- Within our faculty, we have a strong diversity of academics that come from underrepresented groups, we should celebrate this identity and project it externally to attract students from similar underrepresented groups.
- Differentiate between faculty responsibility vs university-wide mechanisms to achieve the above.

Marketing and Identity

- Lack of awareness externally: Does the sector know about the FDS merger?
- If we can't trade (or don't want to trade) on prestige, we must trade on reputation and distinctiveness. Our strong internal strengths are not visible externally.

Industry Relationship

- We need to balance our relationship with industry and ensure that industry engagement does not encroach on academic leadership and freedom.
- **CATCHPHRASE: "Industry engaged, but not industry-led"**
- Industry values physical presence when engaging with students. Speaking to a cohort of 200 students via a zoom room is very different than speaking with a lecture hall with 200 students in it. Industry's interest to engage with us is dependent on the experiences that we offer.

Cost of Study

- Cost of materials is a recurring concern. With the cost of living crisis, students needing to pay for printing, model making materials and software is taking a toll.
- Potential solutions:
 - Bulk purchasing material and software at lower costs and selling them to the students internally.
 - Better integration of cost into assessment design (ways to avoid certain costs).
 - Industry partnerships for recycled or subsidised materials
 - Students suggested integrating certain costs as university fees so that it goes on their HECS.

Curriculum and Pedagogy Challenges

- Questioning whether current teaching models still resonate with this generation of students.
- The significance of balancing between creative thinking vs. critical thinking
- Avoid overly centralised teaching models. Disciplines require different approaches, which contributes to the 'boutique' selling point of our courses.

- Large cohort sizes is making it more and more difficult to engage with country in a meaningful way.

Impact on academic workload

- Improving the points raised above comes at a time cost to academic workloads. Where do we draw the line when things become unsustainable.
- How can we leverage interdisciplinarity and pedagogical cross overs to contribute to each other's teaching. This interdisciplinarity will highlight inequitable workload guidelines between the disciplines.

What Are We Ready to Let Go of?

Prestige-Driven Identity?

- Move away from trying to compete on prestige with the G8. An overemphasis on prestige can undermine our strengths. Instead, we should shift our attention and focus toward:
 - Relevance
 - Innovation
 - Excitement

Centralised Teaching Models

- Rejection of overly standardised/centralised approaches to teaching. We should recognise where we align, but be intentional about preserving and celebrating what makes us distinct.

Constant change mindset

- Let go of the expectation that everything needs to be constantly reformed or replaced. Value continuity where appropriate.

Disconnected Engagement

- Avoid speaking about communities/stakeholders without engaging them directly.

Legacy Structure

- Move beyond “ex-DAB” / “ex-FASS” identities and prioritise a unified FDS identity.